



What is mine, what is not mine

An exercise to stop carrying what was never yours.

VIVIANNE DOS SANTOS

This guide is a self-knowledge resource. It does not replace therapeutic support. If you feel that emotional weight is paralyzing you, please seek professional help. Taking care of yourself is an act of courage.

1. The weight that is not yours

There is a tiredness that cannot be explained by what you did during the day.

It does not come from hours of work, or sleepless nights, or the endless list of things to do. It is a deeper tiredness, an older one, that seems to have lived inside you for so long you no longer know whether it belongs to you or whether it was simply always there.

Maybe you know this feeling well: you wake up already heavy. It is not laziness. It is as if your body knew, before you even opened your eyes, that it would have to hold something that does not belong to it. And it holds it. Every single day.

I know that weight. I carried it for years without understanding what it was. I thought it was part of me, that it was just how I was made, that it was the price of being sensitive, of being a woman, of being a mother, of being a daughter. I thought that feeling so much was a flaw of mine. Until I began to realize that a great part of what I felt did not even belong to me.

Maybe you carry your mother's sadness. The sadness she never put into words, but that you could feel when you were small, in her silence after dinner, in her lost gaze while she hung the laundry. You did not know what it was, but your body knew. And it decided, without anyone asking, that it would help. That it would feel for her. That it would try, somehow, to make her life lighter.

Or maybe you carry your father's frustration. The anger he did not know where to put, the dreams he swallowed, the words he never said. You grew up trying to make up for it. Being perfect. Not causing trouble. Showing that at least something in that family could go right.

Or maybe you carry a sibling's failure, a grandmother's fear, the shame of someone who came before you. Things that do not even have a name, but that weigh on you. That take up space. That steal your air.

And do you know the hardest part? This weight, no matter how heavy it is, became familiar. Almost comfortable. You know its shape, you know how it fits against your body, you know how to move with it on your back. And so, most of the time, you do not question it. You think this is just how life is. That everyone walks around like this. That the tiredness is normal, that the guilt is normal, that the tightness in your chest each morning is just stress.

But it is not. It is not normal to carry what is not yours. It is common, yes. It is frequent. But it is not your natural state.

This is not weakness. This is not playing the victim. It is something that happens in deep and often invisible ways within family systems. Family Constellation shows us that love in a family does not flow only from parents to children: it flows in every direction, it crosses generations, and sometimes it leads us to carry burdens that do not belong to us, driven by a loyalty we are not even aware of.

A child who sees her mother suffer does not think: "I will carry her pain." She simply does it. Because loving, when we are small, is the only tool we have. And that child grows up. Becomes a woman. Becomes a mother. And keeps carrying.

The strangest thing is that this weight, so often, does not even arrive with words. Nobody told you "now you are the one who handles this." Nobody passed you a burden hand to hand, wrapped and labeled. The weight arrived in silence. In the glances, in the sighs, in the things no one said at dinner. In the way your mother smiled when she was shattered inside, and you, at six or seven years old, already knew that smile was a lie. And you knew, without anyone asking, that your job was not to make things worse. It was to be easy. It was to cause no trouble. It was to be, somehow, the solution to something you had not caused.

There are women who carry the weight of their mother and their grandmother at the same time, without ever having heard their grandmother's story in any detail. There are women who feel a guilt they cannot explain, a diffuse responsibility for everything and everyone, and who have never stopped to ask: where does this come from? Is it truly mine?

If you recognize yourself in these words, I want you to know something before we go on: you did nothing wrong. What you did was love. Love in the only way you knew how. And now, perhaps, you are ready to learn another way. One that does not cost you your body. One that does not cost you your life.

You do not need to let go of the love. You need to let go of the weight.

And the first thing you must do in order to let go of the weight is to tell apart what is yours from what is not.

2. The difference between caring and carrying

Caring is an act of love. Carrying is an act of confusion.

They look like the same thing, I know. For a long time, I thought they were. I thought loving someone meant feeling what that person feels, solving what that person cannot solve, suffering when that person suffers. I thought that if I did not carry, I was abandoning. That if I set the weight down, I was saying I did not care.

But that is not how it works.

Caring is standing beside someone. Carrying is putting them on your back.

When you care, you keep your feet on the ground and your eyes on the other person. You are present. You listen. You offer what you can, without losing yourself. When you carry, you lose your ground. You take on the other person's pain as your own. You live their life inside your own body, often without realizing it.

Let me give you some concrete examples, because this needs to leave theory and enter your life.

Caring: Listening to your mother when she is sad and telling her you are there. **Carrying:** Feeling responsible for her sadness and believing you have to make her happy.

Caring: Recognizing that your father had a difficult life and feeling compassion. **Carrying:** Living your life trying to compensate for his frustrations, choosing the profession he wanted, being the person he could not be.

Caring: Helping a sibling who is struggling when they ask. **Carrying:** Taking on their problems as your own, losing sleep over them, feeling that if they fail, you have failed too.

Caring: Remembering a grandmother with tenderness and honoring her memory. **Carrying:** Living with a sadness that is not yours, with a fear that is not yours, with a guilt that belongs to another generation.

Caring: Wanting the best for your children and doing what you can with what you know. **Carrying:** Feeling you must be the perfect mother to make up for everything your own mother did not give you.

Can you see the difference?

Caring keeps you whole. Carrying breaks you in half.

And there is one sign that never fails: when you care, you feel tired at the end of the day, but at peace. When you carry, you feel exhausted before the day has even begun. And it is not the tiredness of the body. It is the tiredness of the soul. It is the tiredness of someone who is living two lives, her own and someone else's, without having chosen to.

Many of us learned to carry so early that we did not realize there was an alternative. Carrying became our identity. We are "the strong one," "the one who can handle anything," "the one who fixes things," "the one who never complains." And strangely, when someone suggests we set the weight down, we feel afraid. As if, without that burden, we would not know who we are.

I will tell you who you are: you are someone who loves deeply. Who loves so much that you confused love with sacrifice. Who loves so much that you forgot you also deserve to be cared for. Who loves so much that you forgot that being light is not selfishness.

True love does not need weight to be real. You can love your mother without carrying her sadness. You can honor your father without living his frustration. You can be connected to your family without being chained to it.

There is a sentence I hear all the time: "If I do not do it, who will?" And the answer, however uncomfortable it may be, is: perhaps no one. Perhaps that person needs to find their own path. Perhaps their pain needs to be felt by them, not by you. That is not cruelty. That is respect. Respect for the other person's ability to live their own life, even if that life includes suffering.

The question is not "do I love or do I not love?" The question is: "Is what I am carrying mine?"

And that is exactly the question we are going to explore now.

3. The exercise: what is mine, what is not

This is the heart of this guide. This is where we leave words behind and step into practice.

Before you begin, I want to ask you something: be gentle with yourself. What you are about to do may seem simple (it is just writing on a piece of paper, after all), but this is not an intellectual exercise. It is an exercise in truth. And truth, when we finally look it in the face, can touch tender places. So go slowly. Do not force anything. If you need to stop, stop. If you need to cry, cry. If you need to close this guide and come back tomorrow, do that. There is no rush.

I am going to ask you to find a quiet place, to take a deep breath, and to give yourself time for this. It is not an exercise to rush through. It is an exercise to do with honesty.

You will need paper and a pen (or, if you prefer, a document on your phone or computer). You are going to create two columns:

What is mine

*(here you will write what
genuinely belongs to you: your*

What is not mine

*(here you will write what you have
been carrying, but that belongs to*

What is mine

choices, your emotions, your desires, your responsibility)

What is not mine

someone else: another person's pain, another person's guilt, another person's fate)

Before you start, let me share a few examples with you. Not for you to copy, but so you understand the kind of honesty this exercise asks for. Every life is different, but there are patterns that repeat, and you may recognize yourself in some of them.

Examples for the column "What is not mine":

"The guilt over my father's drinking." This is not yours. You did not cause it. You cannot cure it. No matter how hard you tried to be the perfect daughter so he would stop, that was never your responsibility. That pain has an origin that is not in you.

"My mother's loneliness." You can be present, you can call, you can visit. But you cannot fill the emptiness she feels. That emptiness existed before you were born, and it is not yours to resolve. You can love her without becoming the solution.

"My parents' unhappy marriage." How many of us grew up feeling that, somehow, we had to hold it all together? Being the bridge between two adults who could not talk to each other? That was never yours. Your pa-

rents' relationship belongs to them.

"My brother's professional failure." You can root for him, you can even help when it is possible. But his life is his life. Feeling guilty because your life is going better, or sabotaging your own success so you do not surpass him, is carrying something that is not yours.

"The sadness I feel and cannot explain." Sometimes we carry emotions that are not even ours, that come from earlier generations, from stories nobody told us, from grief that was never fully mourned. If you feel a sadness that has no story, that does not connect to anything concrete in your life, it may be an inherited weight.

"The need to save everyone." This usually comes from far back. From the child who understood that, if she did not take care of things, nobody would. From the role of mediator you filled in your family without anyone asking. But the need to save is not yours. It is a response to something you lived through. And you can, with time, give it back.

Examples for the column "What is mine":

"How I choose to raise my children." This is yours. Even when you doubt yourself, even when you get it wrong, even when others criticize you. The way you choose to raise them is yours, and you can do it with

awareness without needing to match the model set by your mother, your mother-in-law, or anyone else.

"My right to rest." Yours. Completely yours. You do not need to have done enough to deserve stopping. You do not need to justify rest. It belongs to you.

"My anger when someone crosses my boundaries." Yours. Legitimate. It is not rudeness. It is not ingratitude. It is your body telling you that something is wrong. Listen to it.

"My desire to live differently." Yours. Even if no one in your family ever did things differently. Even if they tell you that you are being selfish. Your desire to grow, to change, to break the pattern, is yours.

"My responsibility for what I do with what I feel." Yours. You do not control what you feel, but you choose what you do with it. And that choice is yours, only yours.

"My pain when someone I love hurt me." Yours. Even if the other person does not acknowledge it. Even if they minimize what you felt. Your pain is legitimate and it belongs to you. And belonging to you means you have the right to feel it, to look at it, and to tend to it.

"My body and its signals." Yours. The aches you feel, the tiredness, the tension, the lump in your throat. Your body speaks to you every day. And it deserves to be heard by you, not silenced so you can keep functioning for everyone else.

Now it is your turn.

Pick up the pen. Take a deep breath. And begin.

You do not have to do it all at once. You can start with two or three things in each column. You can come back tomorrow and add more. This is not an exercise to finish. It is an exercise to begin.

As you write, notice what happens in your body. Maybe you feel a tightness in your chest when you write certain things in the "not mine" column. Maybe you feel relief. Maybe you feel guilt, as if you were betraying someone. All of that is normal. All of that is information.

You do not need to solve anything right now. The simple act of naming, of separating, of looking at what you carry and asking "is this mine?" is already a tremendous step. Most people never ask this question. You are asking it.

A few questions that may help you as you fill in the columns:

"If I imagine setting this weight on the ground, what do I feel?" If you feel relief, it probably is not yours. If you feel afraid to set it down, ask yourself: afraid of what? That the person will be left alone with their pain? That people will stop seeing you as "the strong one"?

"Did I choose to carry this, or did it simply happen?" Most of the weights that are not ours arrived without invitation. They arrived when we were too small to say no.

"If my daughter were carrying this for me, how would I feel?" This question tends to be the most revealing. If it hurts to imagine your daughter carrying your pain, you already know how your mother would feel knowing you carry hers.

"Does this weight move me forward or keep me stuck?" What is genuinely ours, even when it is difficult, pushes us forward. What belongs to someone else, no matter how lovingly we carry it, keeps us stuck.

Write without censoring yourself. Without justifying. Without rationalizing. It does not need to make sense yet. It needs to be true.

4. What to do with what is not yours

Now you have a list. Maybe short, maybe long. Maybe with names that sting, with stories that tighten your throat. Maybe you are looking at the "not mine" column and feeling a mix of relief and terror. Relief at finally seeing clearly. Terror at not knowing what to do with what you see.

Breathe. You do not have to do everything today.

But I want to leave you with a few general guidelines, so you are not left alone with this list. So you know there is a path, even if you do not walk the whole of it right now.

First: acknowledge.

You have already done this. By writing, by naming, by separating what is yours from what belongs to someone else, you have already taken the hardest step. Most people live their entire lives without making this distinction. You made it. Honor that.

Second: give it a name.

There is a difference between feeling a vague weight and being able to say: "What I feel is my mother's sadness. It is not mine." When you name what you carry, you take away its power. It stops being a shapeless shadow and becomes something you can see, touch, and eventually return.

Third: give it back with love.

This is perhaps the most beautiful and most difficult concept in this entire guide. Giving back is not rejecting. Giving back is not abandoning. Giving back is saying, in your heart, something like:

"This is yours. I carried it because I love you, but it does not belong to me. I give it back to you with love. And I return to my own place."

In Family Constellation, there is a principle that says each person has their own place in the system and that, when someone leaves their place to occupy another's, the entire system suffers. When we give back what is not ours, we are not withdrawing love. We are restoring order. We are saying: "Your weight is yours. Mine is mine. And this way, we can both breathe."

This may sound simple. And in truth, the principle is simple. It is the practice that calls for courage, time, and in many cases, professional support.

You can start today with small inner gestures. When you feel that familiar tightness in your chest, ask yourself: "Is this mine?" If the answer is no, imagine setting it gently on the ground. Do not throw it. Do not reject it. Set it down with care, the way you would set down something precious that belongs to someone else.

You can also write a letter you will never send. Addressed to the person whose weight you have been carrying. Not to accuse, not to justify yourself. To give it back. To say: "I saw your pain. I honor what you lived through. But it is not mine to carry." You do not need to send it. Your heart hears.

And you can create a simple ritual. Take that piece of paper where you wrote your list, look at the "not mine" column, and say out loud, for each item: "This is not mine. I give it back with love." Does that sound like very little? Try it. The body hears what the mouth says. And there are words that, when spoken aloud, shift something inside us. They do not change everything. They do not solve everything. But they open a door that was closed before.

There will be days when you manage to set the weight down and feel peace. And there will be days when you pick it back up without realizing it. That is not failure. That is being human. The path is not a straight line. But every time you remember to ask "is this mine?", you are already walking the path.

An important note: if while doing this exercise you feel you are touching very deep wounds, memories of abuse, neglect, or traumatic situations, please do not stay alone with that. This guide is a starting point, not therapy. There are professionals prepared to walk beside you through that process, and seeking them out is an act of courage, not weakness.

What we have just done together is a beginning. A real, honest beginning. Now you know there are things you carry that are not yours. Now you can name them. Now you have a tool to begin separating them. And that is already a great deal.

But between knowing and transforming, there is a path. A path that takes more than understanding. That takes presence, guidance, steps walked with someone who has traveled that ground before and knows where the stones are.

5. The path that begins here

You took the first step. You looked inward. You separated what is yours from what belongs to someone else. And that is brave.

If you feel you want to go deeper, that understanding alone is not enough, that you need a space where someone guides you through that crossing, FreeMe exists for that. It is a program where we work together, step by step, so you can truly give back what is not yours, reclaim your place, and begin to live lighter. It is not just information. It is companionship. It is a path.

You can find everything at viviannedossantos.com/freeme.

But for now, hold on to what you already have. Come back to the exercise whenever you need to. The list is alive, and so are you.

And remember: you are not selfish for wanting to feel light. You are not a bad daughter, a bad mother, a bad sister for wanting to give back what is not yours. You are, finally, someone who is learning to stand in her own place. And that is, perhaps, the most beautiful thing you can do for yourself and for everyone you love.

This guide is a self-knowledge resource based on the principles of systemic Family Constellation and on the clinical and personal experience of the author. It does not constitute diagnosis, therapy, or psychological counseling. If you feel you need professional support, please seek a qualified psychologist or psychotherapist.

© Vivianne dos Santos · viviannedossantos.com



© 2026 Vivianne dos Santos

viviannedossantos.com

freeme.viviannedossantos.com